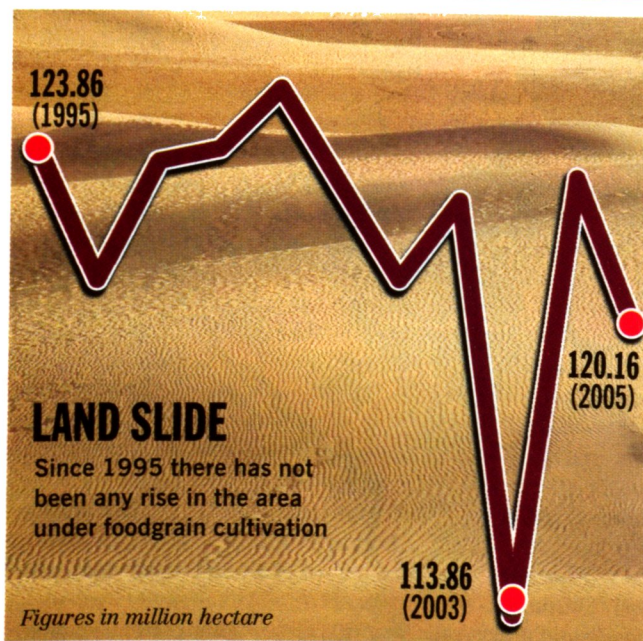




STANDSTILL: There has been no technological breakthrough in recent years

Over 60% rural households own less than a hectare of land.



drop. In the past decade or so, there has been a major diversion of land meant for wheat and rice cultivation into commercial crops such as oilseeds and cotton. Rapid urbanisation and industrialisation, too, are taking up sizeable chunks of land meant for agriculture. This could partly explain the rising protests over the setting up of SEZs by using land meant for agriculture to set up industries. It is estimated that 7.5 lakh hectare of agricultural land are being diverted to other uses every year.

Meanwhile, the ownership of land is highly skewed. Even 15 years ago, over 60 per cent of the rural households owned less than one hectare. Since then, with the growth of population, there has been further fragmentation of land into smaller holdings. While the contribution of agriculture to the GDP has declined from 38 per cent in 1975 to around 19 per cent now, 68 per cent of India's workforce is still dependant on agriculture as a means of livelihood.

To break the vicious cycle, experts propound a dual policy of finding innovative ways to consolidate land holdings and make them more viable, at the same time encouraging diversification so that farm workers can be absorbed by other sectors, thus reducing the dependence on agricultural employment. "By not changing our policy, we are putting a brake on growth. If we have to make agriculture attractive again, we not only need to increase productivity, but also think of the uplift of farmers," says Ramesh Chand, ICAR national professor at the National Centre for Agricultural Economics and Policy Research (NCAP) in Delhi.



"We need to think not only of increasing productivity, but also of the uplift of the farmers."

RAMESH CHAND, PROFESSOR, NCAP